EDUCATIONAL VISION

Canoe Valley School

Vision Statement

Canoe Valley School envisions a community where learning is a whole-person, lived experience—rooted in place, shaped by human and nonhuman relationships, and carried forward by the curiosity and agency of young people. We imagine a school where self-directed, project-based learning invites students into meaningful encounters with the world around them, cultivating the confidence, creativity, and care needed to contribute to a more beautiful, just, and abundant future in an era where environmental and social challenges are proliferating. In this vision, students grow not only in knowledge but in purpose, discovering who they are by engaging deeply with the work, people, and places that call them into becoming their most unique and fully realized selves.

Canoe Valley School serves as a hub and anchor institution for work of a similar spirit in the Canoe Creek Watershed, greater Decorah area and northeast Iowa, and the Driftless region. We see our campus as becoming a nexus for a broader learning community we are cultivating, able to support learners and seekers throughout their lives in partnership with other allied organizations who work here.

Introduction

What follows outlines the key concepts and values that will guide our learning and teaching.

Canoe Valley School will offer a whole-person, relational learning experience that is rooted in the Canoe Creek watershed and shaped by the people and ecology of northeast Iowa and the Driftless region. We pursue whole-person development as individuals and as a group, with a curriculum anchored in student self-directed learning, peer collaboration, interwoven with teacher-led educational experiences. What we are creating is new, arising from this place and from the educational wisdom of the people who have come together to establish this school.

It is also old, in the sense that it follows in the footsteps of longstanding educational traditions that have focused on supporting the development of the whole person, aiming not only for content-area knowledge or skill acquisition (worthwhile goals in their own right), but taking as their central premise the goal of supporting students' growth as complex individuals. We are significantly influenced by well-known educational models practicing versions of this approach, especially Waldorf, Montessori, Reggio Emilia, and the Progressive educational tradition of John Dewey. Each with their unique pedagogical framework, they are thematically consistent in many of their highest aims: asking students to take the lead in their own learning; fostering authentic relationships between students, teachers, and the world; centering students' embodied, lived

experience; and helping them discover themselves and find their unique path in life. We likewise are inspired by a homegrown tradition of whole-person oriented learning that has flourished since at least the 1970s in the Decorah area. This includes forms of home education practiced over many decades by families in Decorah's robust local homeschooling movement; the educational efforts of the Pleasant Valley community, including Pleasant Valley School in the early 1990s; Northeast Iowa Montessori School and Kinderhaus (a Waldorf-inspired preschool), both established in the 2000s; and Red Oak Outdoor School, whose nature-connection program is influenced by Reggio Emilia.

To varying degrees, whole-person educational traditions have held that *place* is key to the educational process, and see local landscapes, with their constituent ecological and cultural patterns, as mediums of learning: living classrooms and teachers rolled into one. In this kind of education, attention to the place-based relations that shape and sustain us is foundational. We take a similar view, and plan to teach and learn *through* the land that surrounds us, the ecologically and culturally rich Canoe Creek watershed of the Upper Iowa River. Our proposed school grew out of this environment quite literally (see X section), our curriculum is interwoven with it, and we envision the school as a core part of a new community development and land stewardship initiative that will contribute to the vibrancy of this wild and storied rural neighborhood. And though we are rooted in a very specific place, we will look beyond our immediate environs to create an accessible, public-oriented institution that is enriched by and in service to the wider world, especially the city of Decorah and Winneshiek County, northeast Iowa, and the Driftless region.

Whole-Person Education

Education thrives on outward connections to the land and to place. But it is also a process of inward development that unfolds in each of us as multi-faceted individuals, and in relationship to each other. This is what we mean by development of the *whole person.* This term is one of the most frequently used to describe non-traditional pedagogies in the U.S. and abroad, and has become a cliché in some educational circles. But the term remains valuable insofar as we actually name what we mean by it. Historically the idea of whole-person education has addressed a bias often found in education in favor of mental-analytical activity—an overwhelming focus on what students know, or are able to do, cognitively. Whole-person education instead encompasses more facets of the individual, as in the well-known 'head, hand and heart' motto. The philosophical lineage of this idea reaches back to the ancient Greeks, and was revived in the eighteenth century by Jean Jacques Rousseau and in the nineteenth by successors like Johann Heinrich Pestalozzi, who made systematic attempts to rebalance education away from mechanistic training of the intellect in favor of the natural development of the individual (remaining on the "path of nature," in Rousseau's terms), including emotional and sensory development.

This rebalancing has been internalized at some level by almost every type of school, mainstream and alternative alike. It’s why most schools offer physical education and (usually these days) some variety of character education as well. However, we draw inspiration from models like Waldorf, Montessori, and Reggio Emilia in taking this approach a step further, insisting on tailoring whole-person education to individuals,

focusing not merely developing the head, hand, and heart toward some preexisting end or social standard—e.g. producing well-formed citizens or well-rounded individuals—but instead doing so to draw out the *one-of-a-kind qualities and purposes* of each individual. This is what is sometimes meant by 'child-led' or 'student-led' education. It is in this sense of supporting human development, supporting the growth of unique, multi-layered individuals for their own flourishing that we intend to pursue whole-person teaching and learning. The 'for their own ends' part is especially important: high quality whole-person learning must begin with supporting innate curiosity, self-motivation, and students' intrinsic desire to learn.

Our Values

If whole-person education is about enabling the growth of unique and multi-faceted human beings, we need a reasonably clear idea of what that growth might entail, what areas of human experience it might involve. To that end, we have identified several developmental areas (capacities, aspects, potentials, etc, work just as well) that we want to support and think we *can* support in our students. These areas can also be expressed as educational values: core *goods* that guide our teaching and learning. We are aiming to go deeper than the traditional head, hand, and heart model, and we view the functions that those body parts name—thinking, sensing, feeling—as working together in each of the areas we list. While what we want to focus on is far from exhaustive in terms of the various human potentials that education can foster, each area is well supported by research and aligns with the values of families we aim to serve, as indicated in the results of the initial community survey connected in late 2025.

1. Self-Motivation and Engagement.

We aim to support our students' capacity to 'show up' to their undertakings, and in this case especially to the learning process itself. This includes supporting the development of their attention, curiosity, enthusiasm, inspiration, perseverance and ambition, leading to the discovery of their gifts, to lifelong learning, and to passion and vocation. This is a cluster of instinctual, embodied states of being that cannot be directly taught, but can be given opportunity to thrive.

In recent decades, evidence has mounted showing that engagement in one's own learning is the single best predictor of positive educational outcomes, and that one major way we can nurture this is by offering students more independence and agency at school. In light of this, schools across the country have embraced learner-centered approaches that tend to view teachers as facilitators of learning as opposed to deliverers of content, offering students more room to follow their interests within the curriculum, and framing learning goals with engagement in mind. The Common Core State Standards in math for example prioritize students' "perseverance" and "making sense" of problems, as opposed to only emphasizing their grasp of mathematical concepts. Steps like these are good, but only scratch the surface of the problem. A recent large-scale study of

student engagement by the Brookings Institution showed that we are in what can be fairly called a disengagement crisis, with fewer than 10% of US students reporting having experiences at school that supported their agency or initiative in learning. We think a big part of the reason why has to do with tendencies that have reached a peak in the last two decades, including making externally derived objects of learning (e.g. lengthy lists of skill-based standards for students to master) the overwhelming focus of classroom activity; an emphasis on learning that is most immediately measurable; rigidity in terms of developmental timelines; and de-prioritization of student agency in the form that their learning takes. We bring the engagement problem up as a national issue, making no judgments about how this trend does or doesn't play out in our local schools. Some of us are former public school teachers, and we recognize the immense talent and imagination that public school teachers and administrators devote to engaging students in their own learning. Further, student engagement is not only driven by independence and formal autonomy: it is relational, and can be sparked by passionate, creative teachers who engage students in myriad ways.

With all this in mind, Canoe Valley has a unique opportunity to deliver on the promise of student agency, and the deep learning it unlocks, taking inspiration from Maria Montessori, John Dewey, and many others. We emphasize knowing when to step into an observer role and letting students lead; prioritizing collaboration between teachers and students in building individualized learning pathways—not just choices within curriculum; and putting self-directed, project-based learning at the center of the school experience.

2. Self-Understanding and Expression.

If self-motivation can be enabled or curtailed by how much agency students feel in the learning process, it ultimately draws its power from deeper sources. Social psychologists have made increasingly explicit connections between our identities and our motivations, showing how who we are—and more importantly how we understand who we are—shapes how engaged we are in our undertakings. This is somewhat intuitive: we tend to want to do things that seem *for us* or *like us*, and not want to do things that seem at odds with our self-concept.

Leaning into this dynamic instead of fighting it can work wonders, especially at the adolescent level, where identity development is in full swing and where experimentation with new roles and ways of being is instinctive. We come back to the importance of self-directed learning, and also to the importance of more direct supports for identity development. For example, in Waldorf education, adolescent students are offered many opportunities to cultivate their expressive selves. This includes creating space for students to lean into both *sympathy* and *antipathy* when it comes to their education—note how a rejection can be as valid a learning moment as an embrace—and to trust themselves more deeply as they engage with curriculum.

We see self-understanding not only as a driver of motivation, but as an end unto itself, among the most important that education can support. Closely related is the aim of drawing out self-expression, which in this instance both results from self-discovery and nurtures it, from simple affirmations of one's identity all the way to passion projects, entrepreneurship, and art making. Arts-based learning in particular is an excellent method for supporting self-understanding and identity development, as Waldorf educators and artists like MC Richards

have long understood, and we plan to support students' artistic expression across the curriculum. There are also more direct methods of self-inquiry we may turn to, including team-building activities, as well as mindfulness-based, contemplative, and embodiment-based practices geared toward adolescents.

Finally, we understand the educational process of self-discovery to include not just students, but teachers as well. "Teaching holds a mirror to the soul," as Parker Palmer puts it, and only a teacher who is in contact with what is most true in themselves will be able to see and draw out what is most true in their students.

3. Relational Capacity and Interdependence.

Our capacity for engaging deeply in our undertakings depends on how well we understand ourselves, and both of these things depend on *what* and even more importantly *who* we are engaging with. As we understand it, we do not self-motivate, do not attain knowledge, do not understand and express ourselves—do not *grow*—except in authentic relationship to others.

Emphasis on the way human beings learn and grow in relationship is truly ancient. Education reformers keen to demonstrate the limitations of ‘objective’ or detached approaches to learning have pointed to examples ranging from the Socratic method to Lakota principle of *mitakuye oyasin* (all my relations) to show how our capacity for interdependence enriches learning by turning it into a three-dimensional encounter with other living beings. And insofar as relationships invariably involve our first-person experience, they tend toward practical, useful learning, a dynamic that Gregory Cajete calls "education for life’s sake." Interdependence among people, and between people and the natural world, always exists but is often muddied by deep-rooted myths of the "separate self," in Joanna Macy’s language.

Education can help address this separation, and return us to awareness of our connection to each other and to the places we inhabit. This need not imply moralizing, or insisting on standards of ecological-mindedness, as Macy reminds us. We find connection with others and with the more-than-human world in our own way, through our authentic selves, not by being virtuous, but through expanding our self-interest: realizing our interests and those of other beings are connected.

Teachers can help students find their own way to this kind of connection by modeling it. Teachers lead the way in creating a culture of relational learning, modeling authentic encounters with other humans, other species, and the communities they comprise. They also do this as they introduce subject areas and guiding questions, inspiring students to make their own deep connections to the beings, objects, and ideas they encounter as they learn through participation in subject-area discourses. Teachers take the initiative in creating a culture of inclusion in a similar way: in Palmer’s language, good teachers ‘join selves and subjects in the fabric of life,’ creating an atmosphere of authenticity and respect for difference in which our interconnectedness can flourish.

Finally, relational learning goes beyond the teacher-student relationship. Parents can model this kind of connectedness at home, and students provide each other with relational sparks for learning at school. Peer

learning is a central part of our educational culture, and one student's curiosity about the beings and subjects they encounter as they learn often reverberates, inspiring curiosity and helping ignite the engagement of others.

4. Connection to Place.

Data is abundant in environmental psychology and other fields that contact with the outdoors is good for all of us. It can reduce stress and lower blood pressure, enhance concentration and improve mood. It can help children in school regulate emotionally and improve attention. For these reasons alone, a strong emphasis on place is well supported as a strategy to support academic success.

But more than that, the places around us, peopled by so many different and varied creatures, are among our most instructive teachers, not only about the world, but about ourselves and our position in it. Liberty Hyde Bailey, in arguing for his particular practice of nature study, writes, “Good nature-study teaching develops personality and encourages the pupil to think for himself and to maintain an individual relation to his world.” This outlook resonates with other more contemporary nature-connection approaches like the Coyote Mentoring model that aim to reconnect children (and adults) with the more-than-human world in holistic ways.

Engagement with place actualizes the relations between self and others, inviting students to consider all the ways in which they are many, a unique nexus in a diffuse flux of social, cultural, material, ecological activities. We develop in and through our worlds, and our lives gain form through the habits and practices of tending to the relations large and small that sustain us. Our goal, through a rigorous attention to place and the practices of noticing and gratitude that requires, is to help students discover ways they are enfolded in communities, human and nonhuman.

From this commitment flows an ethic of conviviality, its etymology voicing the idea of *living together*. By accounting for our own world, including its precarious fragility and contingency, we begin to become sensitive to the ways others’ lives are equally extensive and dependent—on the land and its offerings, on stories and histories, patterns of culture and activity. We become aware of common interests, the ways our lives overlap and support one another, and bind us into interdependent communities. Our challenge, as ethical agents, becomes how to notice those who sustain us, and the ways they depend on us to sustain them.

5. Knowledge Foundations.

For us, the attainment of knowledge does not simply mean remembering content, which is well and good, but, as it does for most schools, the development of foundational knowledge for us includes a range of higher-order reasoning, problem-solving, and critical thinking skills. This is the bread-and-butter of traditional secondary education (and higher education for that matter as well) and we view it as a core duty to help students develop a solid foundation in this kind of knowledge. We also see the development of knowledge as

occurring not just through thinking, but through experience that happens at the level of the whole person: what we know will be formed and enriched by who we are, what we want, how we show up, how we relate, and so on.

This is part of the reason why we place so much emphasis on self-directed learning: when we follow our innate curiosity, and when we have the opportunity to develop learning goals for ourselves and participate meaningfully in crafting curriculum, we begin to embody and live out the skills and knowledge we develop. This does not mean we substitute opinions or subjective 'takes' for knowledge. In John Dewey's terms, when it is "carried" by our experience, knowledge does not simply become subjective, but instead it is substantiated, renewed, and offered back to the world in a more useful form.

We are attentive to foundations—to the skills and capacities students will need for success at the postsecondary level and in their future lives and work—and we believe they are best developed through experience, in the context of students' actual lives, interests, and relationships. We draw on the idea of *livsoplysning* (education for life), a core principle of the folk school movement that originated with the work of N.F.S. Grundtvig, which favors local, practical knowledge that is relevant to the lives of real people and communities and calls attention to educational overreliance on abstractions.

What we have in mind is likewise in harmony with place-based forms of knowledge found in the work of Robin Wall Kimmerer and other indigenous thinkers, which is to say situated and relational, and also in Kimmerer's case especially, advancing hybrid ways of knowing that interweave scientific methods with attentiveness to the stories and mysteries of individual beings, places, and ecosystems. Here inquiry and observation are still key methods, but instead of isolating us from abstract things, inquiry involves and implicates us in the independent reality of what is being observed. This is true whether we're observing the natural world, exploring a historical period, or studying a branch of mathematics: even seemingly abstract things are not quite so abstract when we look more closely, bring them into our lived experience, and allow them shape us as we try to understand them.

6. Responsibility and Purpose.

As students come to understand themselves, engage authentically with others, and develop knowledge that is grounded in lived experience, a further capacity begins to emerge: a sense of responsibility for the worlds they inhabit and unique purposes as they live into that responsibility. Responsibility, in our view, is not a duty imposed from outside, nor a moralistic expectation of "good behavior," but an inevitable outgrowth of the previous values. When students feel genuinely connected—to their own motivations, to their identities, to their peers and communities, and to the places and subjects they study—they begin to recognize that their actions matter. They see themselves as participants in an ongoing story rather than as passive recipients of information or isolated individuals pursuing private aims. Donna Haraway breaks the word down, presenting "response-ability" in ways that highlight our emergent capacity to show up for those with whom our lives intertwine. Robin Wall Kimmerer likewise frames responsibility as a practice of reciprocity: an understanding that knowledge, relationships, and places give to us, and that we in turn can give back through care, creativity, and purposeful action.

Rich possibilities for purpose arise from this understanding of responsibility. When students experience learning as interdependent, they begin to appreciate the reciprocal nature of their encounters with people, places, and ideas. They notice how their choices shape the learning environment, how their presence affects others, and how their unique gifts, care, and principled action can strengthen the places and communities they belong to, and create a more beautiful, just and abundant future. Responsibility becomes less about compliance and more about contribution: the desire to offer something meaningful back to the world that has shaped them.

We aim to cultivate responsibility and purpose by creating opportunities for students to take ownership of their learning environments, their projects, and their relationships. This includes place-based learning, collaborative decision-making, community-based learning, ecological engagement, and real-world problem-solving that highlights the impact of their actions.

Ultimately, students' sense of responsibility and purpose are maturations of their whole-person learning. When students recognize themselves as agents within interconnected systems—social, ecological, and intellectual worlds—they begin to act with intention and creativity. They learn to balance freedom with accountability, individuality with community, and curiosity with care, and recognize themselves as participants in a great, shared story. In this way, our students understand themselves and their place in the world, and ways they can serve and shape it.

Our Methods

If whole-person learning centers on supporting and/or re-activating our innate curiosity and desire to learn (self-motivation and engagement in the learning process) as well as on identity development (self-understanding and expression), then the educational experience we provide needs to be meaningfully self-directed. It needs to provide expansive freedom for students to choose subjects they are interested in, the form their learning takes, and their educational goals: to learn in a way that derives from their own agency and reflects who they are.

On the other hand, if whole-person learning happens in meaningful relationship with others, with the nonhuman world, and within communities (relational capacity and interdependence, connection to place) and is oriented toward creativity, reciprocity, and principled action in a broader social story (responsibility and purpose), it needs to go beyond self-directed learning alone. It can be activated through teacher-led educational experiences and projects, peer learning, place-based service-learning, and participation in school culture and community life. Further, if whole-person learning involves attunement to the opportunities and exigencies of the broader educational world, including those related to post-secondary education and future work, it needs to engage with competency frameworks and core skill pathways.

A great deal of balancing and interweaving is necessary, in other words, between learning that is truly self-directed by students as individuals and learning that is structured, inspired, activated, provoked by teachers, parents, and community members, as well as shaped by external validating institutions like colleges, our accreditor, and the Iowa Department of Education.

The central tension in play here, which most self-directed schools face, is between two equally strong convictions:

- Children and teenagers learn best by following their innate curiosity and real-world needs, alongside their peers, and that this process is often curtailed when adults bring numerous learning goals and rigid methods to bear on students.
- Adults have the responsibility to initiate learning opportunities that will benefit students, opportunities they might not or would not otherwise have.

This tension is important, and shouldn't be immediately resolved. We see it rather as a useful problem and a guide as we put our educational values into practice.

Turning to those values, the questions we ask are: how can student *and* teacher/adult leadership in learning best work together to support whole-person development? Together, how can they support the areas of development that we value most (see above), in our educational offerings, in the rhythms of our school day and year, and in our school culture?

Our answer is what we call *self-directed learning, together*, an approach that encourages students to shape their own learning, and also engage in teacher-led and group educational experiences designed to support that learning. Below is a brief overview of how this method works in practice; for a closer look, see our Curriculum Overview document.

Self-Directed Learning, Together

Self-directed learning, together is Canoe Valley School's hybrid approach to teaching and learning. It activates student self-direction with the relational energy provided by teachers, peers, families, community members, and place. Students have substantial freedom to pursue their own learning goals, design projects, play and explore, while also participating in teacher-initiated educational experiences and projects designed to inspire, support, and deepen their learning. Students likewise have the responsibility to contribute to a flourishing school culture, and be of service to the place we live and the wider world.

In concrete terms, this approach is twofold. On the one hand students have ample time during each school day to play and explore individually and with peers; to pursue projects that can be, but need not be, aligned to any immediate curricular goals; to take elective classes, participate in student clubs, and apprenticeships.

On the other hand, teachers lead an interdisciplinary, project-based, core curriculum that engages the school's values and core competencies, and prioritizes increasing student agency and independence in project development over time.

In this more structured component, teachers lead short educational experiences (e.g. mini-lessons, demonstrations) that introduce core subject areas and inspire student engagement, and are tied to longer follow-up projects. Together, these experiences and projects at Canoe Valley replace traditional core classes. Experiences and projects are designed to support whole-person growth in our six developmental areas in the following ways:

- Experiences and projects support **self-motivation and engagement** with relational teaching approach designed to spark student curiosity and model whole-person development alongside a project-based learning model that, in the lower level, provides ample room for customization and collaborative project development by students, and over time and especially in the upper level, self-led project development by students. This area is also supported through many of the modalities listed for the other areas below.
- Experiences and projects support **self-understanding and expression** through the same relational teaching approach, and by regularly integrating expressive and arts-based learning; contemplative, reflective, and mindfulness/embodiment-based practice; and teambuilding activities and expeditions.
- They support **relational capacity, connection to place, and responsibility and purpose** through the same relational teaching approach, and through place-based learning, 1-on-1 mentorship with teachers, group reflection, committee work, teambuilding activities and expeditions, collaborative and service-learning opportunities (including collaboration and service-learning requirements for a certain number of projects per semester).
- They support students' developing **knowledge foundations** through the same relational teaching model (of course!), through what we call *competency pathways* (see below), as well as through many of the modalities listed above, in particular place-based learning that emphasizes formation of practical, lived knowledge.

Experiences and projects are designed with multi-age groupings in mind, and projects are interdisciplinary and may vary in length and scope: from long-duration, large-group (e.g. a watershed restoration project) to shorter and more individualized (e.g. studying the flow of power and authority in civic texts). Teachers also lead a mini-course at the start of each year in the school's form of self-directed learning: why the school uses it and how it works over time. This includes the fundamentals of project-based learning and project design, which are expanded in mini-lessons throughout the year.

Lower Level to Upper Level Arc

Crucially, students increasingly take ownership of project design as they progress from the school's lower to upper level. Early in the lower level, students primarily engage with teacher-designed projects/project areas that are pre-aligned to core competencies, and offer significant room for differentiation/customization

depending on student interest and developmental need (e.g. a place portrait where students are engaging in scientific inquiry at varying levels of complexity depending on readiness, and gearing the results toward a specific audience with self-chosen mediums of presentation or expression).

As they approach the end of the lower level and begin the upper, students are encouraged to self-design and design with peers a certain number of projects per semester, collaborating with teachers to align them to specific competencies. In the upper level this freedom expands: students' project work is primarily self-designed and designed with peers. Teachers continue to collaborate with students to align their projects to the school's core competencies, and help students tailor their project work to suit their (often evolving) anticipated post-secondary paths.

Competency Pathways

To support students' developing knowledge foundations, experiences and projects within the core curriculum (whether teacher-initiated or student-led) are aligned to skills and knowledge in the school's core subject areas. This alignment creates what we call *competency pathways*, a skill and knowledge model that supports, rather than overshadows, self-directed activity. For a closer look at the model, see our Curriculum Overview Moreover, the school's competency framework is itself designed as much as possible to support whole-person development as outlined above.

Documenting Learning and Advancement Requirements

Learning and teaching at Canoe Valley School aims at the outcomes listed in our Curriculum Handbook.

Progress toward these outcomes is documented in multi-media portfolios of student work, and through a learning narrative that is written by students and teachers, commenting on work included in the portfolio. Students are asked to comment on their own growth, challenges, and evolving relationship to the learning process, asking, for example, how did I 'show up' to this project? How did it feel? How does it reflect my curiosity and interest? What challenges arose and how did I navigate them? Students may be offered sample prompts by teachers that make use of the school's language for whole-person development, but they are not required to use such language, and should choose (or invent) a language for reflection and self-evaluation that works for them.

Teachers offer comments on student growth in five of our six developmental areas, mostly* non-evaluative in nature. These may take the form of observations of student growth as demonstrated in the portfolio, and also may arise from informal observation of students' day-to-day activities. In the sixth area, Knowledge Foundations, teachers provide brief, growth-oriented evaluations of students' developing fluency in the school's core competencies. See the Content Area and Competency Outline section of our Curriculum Handbook for sample fluency indicators.

For advancement purposes in the upper level (i.e. for graduation), these evaluations take a pass/fail form: either the student demonstrates sufficient fluency** in a particular competency or they do not. In the upper level, students are also asked to select a small number of high-quality forms of external validation that complement their portfolios and learning narratives, and reflect their intended path after graduation. This might include standardized tests like the ACT, but might also include juried exhibitions or competitions, apprenticeship sign-offs, or externally validated rites of passage. Also in the upper level, students are asked to complete a capstone service learning project as a requirement for graduation. As students consider which external validation methods and capstone project to pursue, a key question they consider is how it manifests their purpose, and their responsibility to give back to the community from which (and into which) they are emerging as adults.

We are currently exploring advancement possibilities for the lower level. At minimum, students will be required to demonstrate basic fluency in the school's approach to project design–as taught in the mini-course referenced above and in the project-based learning process itself–and readiness to participate in the more expansive opportunities for self-designed project work in the upper level.

* Outside Knowledge Foundations, in our other five developmental areas we value a non-evaluative approach, except in a few key places. These are indicated in the Portrait of a Learner document when we use the word "fluency."
** What we mean by "sufficient fluency" will be defined by the Faculty Leadership Circle ahead of the school's opening.

Beyond the Core Method

This is an overview of the methods that underlie the school’s core academic program. The core program is only one part of the curriculum. As mentioned above, open-ended play and peer learning are central, and there are numerous other curricular features at the school that are designed to support students’ development. These include elective classes and co-curriculars; participation in school operations (including the opportunity to participate in educational farm operations) and governance; group councils and showcases of student work; off-site expeditions; simple group rituals that give rhythm to the school day/calendar and mark seasonal change; and a weeklong course at the start of the year that introduces students to the campus, farm and local environment, inspired by the 'neckdown' model. Parents and community members are also part of the learning ecosystem. Apprenticeships connect students with local mentors, while quarterly showcases invite families and community members into relationship with student work. See our Curriculum Handbook for more on the core learning program and these other features of our curriculum.